sixty-one, chairman of ACC and deputy chairman of TELCO; Freddie A. Mehta, fifty-three, the first recruit to the prestigious Tata Administrative Service and later chief economic adviser to the Tata Group; Naval Tata, seventy-seven; and Ratan, forty-three.

In reality, however, the choice was more restricted. Moolgaokar and Naval Tata were too old to be serious contenders. The former was just two years younger than JRD and the latter was his age. To keen industry watchers, it must have appeared that JRD would finally have to choose between Mody and Palkhivala. Both were comparatively young and had strong credentials. But of the two, the former was seen as the clear frontrunner.

Palkhivala was an unabashed critic of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, who had returned to power in a landslide victory in 1980. He was a staunch supporter of the Janata Party, which had arrested Indira Gandhi and incarcerated her twice. It would have been imprudent to run the risk of earning the displeasure of the feisty Prime Minister. So, Mody looked like the likely winner.

Surprisingly, virtually none of the close observers of the Tata Group could make a correct assessment of who would replace JRD as the chairman of TIL. And when the decision was announced on 21 October 1981, it took many by surprise. Few expected the soft-spoken, introverted Ratan to be appointed JRD's successor. One leading magazine termed it an 'unexpected choice' and added that JRD, who was 'well-known as a conservative captain of industry who looks extremely carefully before he leaps … leapt in an unexpected direction' when he appointed Ratan as the chairman.

Many professional technocrats shared the same view and openly criticized the appointment, declaring that in the selection, 'the much-vaunted Tata reputation for professionalism had suffered a blow'. A leading business daily wrote that 'Tata directors like Nani Palkhivala, Russi Mody and Minoo Mody [CEO, Tata Sons] were bitterly disappointed at Ratan's choice.' Ratan himself, with his characteristic humility, said: 'I was as pleasantly surprised—it was as if my name had been something else.'

There was much speculation in the corridors of Bombay House on why Ratan was chosen. Many attributed the appointment to the fact that Ratan and JRD were alike. Both shared the irrepressible urge to take to the skies at